

Arabic Metaphor Identification

Procedure (AraMIP)

Annotation Instructions

25 June 2026

A) Introduction

AraMIP is a two-stage annotation procedure for identifying and classifying metaphor-related words in Arabic text. It extends Metaphor Identification Procedure, Vrije Universiteit (MIPVU) by adding a second stage that maps identified metaphor-related words (MRWs) onto the Arabic rhetorical classification.

The two stages are designed to be applied sequentially: Stage 2 is only performed for lexical units that receive a positive metaphor-related identification at Stage 1.

- Stage 1 – Metaphor identification with MIPVU

Stage 1 follows the MIPVU procedure without modification. Each lexical unit in the text is examined individually to determine whether it is a MRW.

- The unit of annotation is the **lexical unit** — annotation is applied word by word.
- Each lexical unit receives one of the following codes: **MRW indirect**, **MRW direct**, **MRW implicit**, **MFlag**, or **MRW negative**.
- Stage 1 makes no reference to Arabic rhetorical categories.
- The use of supplementary codes **DFMA** and **WIDLII** is covered in Section C.

- Stage 2 – Arabic Rhetorical Classification

Stage 2 classifies MRW-positive items according to the Arabic rhetorical tradition.

- The unit of annotation is the **rhetorical construction** – classification may span more than one lexical unit identified at Stage 1.
- Each MRW-positive item (or cluster of lexical units forming a single rhetorical construction) receives one of the following codes: ***al-isti'āra***, ***al-kināya***, or ***al-tashbīh***.
- Lexical units identified in Stage 1 as **MRW indirect** are expected to correspond with ***al-isti'āra*** and ***al-kināya***.

Lexical units identified in Stage 1 as **MRW direct** are expected to correspond with ***al-tashbīh***.

Lexical units identified in Stage 1 as **MRW implicit** do not have a corresponding Stage 2 flag.

Lexical units identified in Stage 1 as **MFlag** will be incorporated into the ***al-tashbīh*** rhetorical annotation and not formally annotated in Stage 2.

B) Identification of lexical units

In Stage 1, annotation is by lexical units. These are usually single orthographic words. Entities such as acronyms, proper names, and numbers are treated as individual lexical units. Multi-word proper names are examined component by component.

For Arabic clitics, decompose the clitic from its host and examine each component as a lexical unit.

C) Stage 1: MIPVU

Follow Steps 1-4 with each lexical unit to see if it is any of the following: “**MRW, indirect**”, “**MRW, direct**”, “**MRW, implicit**”, or “**MFlag**”.

For new lexical units not in the dictionary (e.g. novel hyphenated items like *honey-hunting*), split them into their component parts and treat each part as a lexical unit to be analysed individually.

- If there is a lexical unit that you cannot understand, mark it as Discarded For Metaphor Analysis (**DFMA**).
- If you suspect a lexical unit is a metaphor, but it is not certain, add the code When In Doubt, Leave It In (**WIDLII**).

Step 1. Is the lexical unit an indirect metaphor? (MRW, indirect)

An indirect metaphor compares two unlike things by suggesting the comparison rather than stating it outright. E.g. Ahmed hunts the ball on the football field.

1. Identify **contextual meaning**: decide what the unit means in this specific context and situation.
2. Use the dictionary to find the **basic meaning**, which is the first definition for the word. We are using *Mu‘jam al-lugha al-‘arabiyya al-mu‘āšira* with the interface provided at Almaany.com.
3. See if the **basic meaning** is distinct from the **contextual meaning** (e.g. separate numbered meanings in the dictionary, or a clear difference in meaning, or the contextual meaning is absent).
4. See if the **contextual meaning** is related to the **basic meaning** by some similarity across domains. If the relation is purely generalisation or synecdoche (*al-majāz*), do not treat it as metaphor.

➤ If 3 and 4 are positive, mark the lexical unit as “**MRW, indirect**”, otherwise, proceed to Step 2.

Step 2. Is the lexical unit a direct metaphor? (MRW, direct)

A direct metaphor explicitly states that one thing is (like) another. E.g. Ahmed is a lion on the football field

If the lexical unit was not coded as “**MRW, indirect**” in Step 1:

1. Does the sentence suddenly talk about something from a different domain (e.g. animals, war, journeys) to describe the same person or event?
2. Is the different material introduced with a **direct comparison** (e.g. “X is like Y”, “X is Y”, or similar).
3. If there is a comparison, do the compared entities belong to completely different domains?
4. Does the comparison help you understand the real person or event (e.g. ‘lion’ means brave, strong)?

➤ If steps 1–4 are positive, mark the lexical unit as “**MRW, direct**”, otherwise, proceed to Step 3.

Step 3. Is the lexical unit an implicit metaphor? (MRW, implicit)

This is for words like pronouns and small verbs that **stand in for** something that was an indirect or direct metaphor earlier, such as *he, she, it, this, that, they, do, is, has, will*.

E.g. The coach attacked the referee. He went too far this time.

1. Does the word **refer back** to a previous “**MRW, indirect**” or a “**MRW, direct**”?

➤ If it does, mark the lexical unit as “**MRW, implicit**”,

- If the lexical unit is also metaphorical in its own right (by the indirect test), code it as **Metimpl** (both metaphorical and implicit).

Step 4. Is the lexical unit a metaphor flag? (MFlag)

1. Does the lexical unit function as a signal of potential cross-domain mapping:
 - If it is one of the specified **simile/analogy markers** (e.g. *like, as, more/less than, comparative + than*; in Arabic: *كأن، مثل، شبه، مثيل*), or
 - One of the **comparison words** (e.g. *compare, comparison, comparative, same, similar, analogy, analogue*; in Arabic: *يشبه، يماثل، يحاكي، مشابه، مماثل*), or
 - One of the **mental conception markers** (e.g. *regard as, conceive of, see as, imagine, think/talk/behave as if, as if*; in Arabic: *كأنما، كما لو*)

➤ then mark it as “**MFlag**”.

D) Stage 2: Arabic Rhetorical Classification

In Stage 2, the unit of annotation is the **rhetorical construction** rather than the individual lexical unit. Once Stage 1 has identified MRW-positive items, the annotator should identify the full span of the rhetorical construction to which those items belong and annotate that construction as a whole.

- It is expected that **MRW indirect** will correspond with ***al-isti'āra*** and ***al-kināya***. The difference between the two is that in ***al-kināya***, the literal meaning is possible, even though another intended meaning is also understood. Whereas in ***al-isti'āra*** the literal meaning is not possible.
 - ***al-isti'āra***: *Ahmed is a lion on the football field.* (This is not literally possible.)
 - ***al-kināya***: *Ahmed has long arms on the football field.* (This is literally possible.)
- It is expected that **MRW, direct** will correspond with ***al-tashbīh***.
 - **MRW implicit** and **MFlag** are not annotated in Stage 2.

E) Worked examples

أحمد يصطاد الكرة في ملعب كرة القدم

Ahmed hunts the ball on the football field.

Lexical unit	Stage 1: MIPVU Annotation	Stage 2: Arabic Span Annotation
أحمد	MRW negative	<i>isti'āra</i>
يصطاد	MRW indirect	<i>isti'āra</i>
الكرة	MRW negative	<i>isti'āra</i>
في	MRW negative	negative
ملعب	MRW negative	negative
كرة	MRW negative	negative
القدم	MRW negative	negative

أحمد طويل اليد في ملعب كرة القدم

Ahmed is long-armed on the football field.

Lexical unit	Stage 1: MIPVU Annotation	Stage 2: Arabic Span Annotation
أحمد	MRW negative	<i>kināya</i>
طويل	MRW indirect	<i>kināya</i>
اليد	MRW indirect	<i>kināya</i>
في	MRW negative	negative
ملعب	MRW negative	negative
كرة	MRW negative	negative
القدم	MRW negative	negative

رأيت أسداً في ملعب كرة القدم

I saw a lion on the football field.

Lexical unit	Stage 1: MIPVU Annotation	Stage 2: Arabic Span Annotation
رأيت	MRW negative	negative
أسداً	MRW indirect	<i>isti'āra</i>
في	MRW negative	negative
ملعب	MRW negative	negative
كرة	MRW negative	negative
القدم	MRW negative	negative

أحمد كالأسد في ملعب كرة القدم

Ahmed is like a lion on the football field.

Lexical unit	Stage 1: MIPVU Annotation	Stage 2: Arabic Span Annotation
أحمد	MRW negative	<i>tashbīh</i>
ك	MFlag	<i>tashbīh</i>
الأسد	MRW direct	<i>tashbīh</i>
في	MRW negative	negative
ملعب	MRW negative	negative
كرة	MRW negative	negative
القدم	MRW negative	negative

F) Further Annotation Notes

➤ Link to dictionary: [Muʿjam al-lugha al-ʿarabiyya al-muʿāṣira](#) via [Almaany.com](#)

- 1) The dictionary contains the “basic” meaning as the first item, and it also contains other meanings. If the contextual meaning is listed as one of the other meanings (i.e. it is not the basic meaning), the key in determining whether the contextual meaning is rhetorical is the **gap** or **distance** between the basic meaning and the contextual meaning. If there is a large gap, then it may be rhetorical. If the two meanings are from the same domain – such as different meanings of تاريخ, or عصر vs زمان – the gap is small and this is not rhetorical. This understanding is based on points 3 in each of the Steps 1 and 2 of the MIPVU procedure.
- 2) A dictionary entry may have:
 - **Homonyms** – one word with multiple unrelated meanings. Such as بيت in poetry and بيت meaning house.
 - **Polysemous words** – one word with multiple related meanings. Such as رأس as a body part and رأس as a geographical feature (headland/cape where a piece of land sticks out from the main body.)

It is not clear whether our [dictionary](#) is consistent in presenting these as (1) different numbered entries, (2) different bulleted entries under the same number, or (3) separate entries in the same page.

In any case, we should be aware that an entry may contain homonyms, and the different homonyms must be examined independently to determine the relevant “basic” meaning.
- 3) If the first meaning is simply the **derivation (al-ishtiqāq)** of the word, this is not taken as the “basic” meaning.
- 4) For **names**, each part of the name needs to be analysed independently, as per the MIPVU specification.
- 5) We should use MIPVU’s procedure to annotate metaphor-related words, even if the lexical unit is a **conceptualised metaphor / dead metaphor**. This is consistent with the MIPVU theory, and existing work and practice.
- 6) If the sentence clearly contains a very simple and obvious **mistake** in transcription, it is appropriate to correct this, and to analyse the corrected sentence, rather than marking it DFMA (“Discarded For Metaphor Analysis”). Similarly, if you can discern what the meaning is despite an apparent mistake, it is appropriate to annotate it rather than marking as DFMA.

- 7) For the purpose of this work, all instances of *al-tashbīh* must include the **simile element** (*'adāt al-tashbīh*). This aligns with the MIPVU convention, and some of the classical Arabic sources. This means that the effective simile (*al-tashbīh al-balīgh*) such as “هو أسد” is considered to be *isti'āra* rather than *tashbīh*.
- 8) A **comparison word** should be annotated as MFlag only if it is related to a MRW-direct. For example, the word “like” in the sentence “The man looked like his father” is a factual statement, and not MFlag. Whereas the word “like” in the sentence “Her face shone like the moon” involves a comparison across different domains, and is therefore MFlag, with “moon” being MRW-direct.
- 9) Many Arabic **proper names** encode a figurative meaning, which can artificially inflate the numbers of metaphors in a text. Therefore, proper names are not evaluated for metaphors.
- 10) **Nested rhetorical devices** will be handled by the INCEpTION annotation platform.